

NOT THE RADICAL REPUBLIC: LIBERAL IDEOLOGY AND CENTRAL BLANDISHMENT IN FRANCE, 1901–1914*

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ABSTRACT. *Madeleine Rebérioux was right to wonder whether France was truly a 'Radical republic' in the years between the Dreyfus affair and the Great War. Archives only opened or explored since Rebérioux published in 1975, and the re-interpretation of older newspaper sources, show that control of the Third Republic was still hotly contested in those years. The Radicals tried to build a republic in their own image, but in a situation where left and right were closely balanced, they were almost always foiled. Crucial to this process was a politically republican but socially conservative centre – best typified by the A.R.D. The A.R.D. wanted a Third Republic frankly favourable to the interests of big business. Since it held the parliamentary balance of power between the left and a right only partly republican, it generally got its way. Statistical sources also support this interpretation.*

Seventeen years ago, Madeleine Rebérioux took the received wisdom on France before the Great War and added a question mark to it – naming her account *La République Radicale*.¹ Historians have not rushed to answer the question, and it would certainly be difficult to find another label as alliterative or clear. Radicalism had an obvious shape and continuity.² Most of the groups around it did not. Treating the period from the Dreyfus affair to the Great War as the Radical era, and blaming the Radicals for everything that went wrong, also made a comfortably digestible chapter of it. Even Rebérioux – though reaching for a more fundamental revision – was generally content to attack the Radicals from their left, instead of from their right as most of her predecessors did.³ It was difficult not to. The most available sources on the

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¹ Madeleine Rebérioux, *La République Radicale*? (Paris, 1975). Originally volume 11 of the *Nouvelle Histoire de la France contemporaine*, it has also been re-issued in English translation as half of *The Third Republic from its origins to the Great War*, trans. J. R. Foster (Cambridge, 1984) along with J.-M. Mayeur's volume on the first years of the Republic.

² See e.g. Claude Nicolet, *Le Radicalisme* (Paris, 1961). For a summary of and a reply to attempts to trivialize the Radicals and their achievements from the end of the Second Empire to c. 1902, see Katherine Auspitz, *The radical bourgeoisie* (Cambridge, 1982), esp. p. 166.

³ Jacques Chastenet, who wrote the *Histoire de la Troisième République* (7 vols Paris, 1952–63), sat for the A.R.D. Georges Bonnefous, who wrote most of the *Histoire Politique de la Troisième République* (7 vols Paris, 1959–67) was both an M.P. and a vice-president of the Republican

period were the mass press of Paris (right-wing and venal), and parliamentary histories written by politicians who made a career of opposing the Radicals.

Since 1975, new sources have broadened our perspective to the point where we can begin to answer Reberiou. It now seems that few of the first fourteen years of the twentieth century really belonged to the Radical party. Instead – in a situation where left and right were closely balanced – the casting vote was almost always held by a politically republican but socially conservative centre – best typified by the Republican and Democratic Alliance of France (A.R.D. from its French initials). Almost always, the Alliance tilted the balance against the Radical republic.

This argument contributes to a trend of revision currently giving the Third Republic far more credit for political workability than had heretofore been done.⁴ It tends to show two things: that both the Radicals and the centre (historically neglected groups, which often hated each other) contributed the most to a respectable level of stability, and that the Radicals and the Third Republic have too often been seen from the perspectives of their enemies, and of Anglo-Saxons quick to imagine that a democracy which does not work as theirs does, does not work at all.⁵

I

What was French Radicalism? Far too often it is still assumed to be a version of *laissez-faire*, based on the assumption that individual freedom is the most important value in a democracy, and that individual freedom is best protected by keeping governments from doing anything. In France this view was popularized through the works of Emile Chartier – who wrote under the pseudonym ‘Alain’, and who named his most famous book *Éléments d’une doctrine radicale*.

More than twenty-six years ago Peter Larmour – whose sympathies lay elsewhere – was nevertheless forced to conclude that the Radicals in fact paid Alain almost no attention at all. Radical ideology certainly had its swirls and variations – like that of any consensus party. Its ranks contained a considerable number of small ‘o’ opportunists as well. Even so, Susan Mach has shown that an official core to the Radical party’s beliefs did exist – one quite different from *laissez-faire*. A general reading of the Radical press shows those beliefs to have been fairly consistent at any time from the beginnings of the twentieth century until the fall of France in 1940. Those beliefs were based on the small ‘l’ liberal doctrine of *solidarisme* – which urged using the power of the state to protect the individual’s freedom of choice. Classic radicalism was being

Federation (a party which united the survivors of Royalism and Bonapartism with former Centrists who had evolved to the right over the Dreyfus affair).

⁴ See for example Robert J. Young, *Power and pleasure: Louis Barthou and the French Third Republic* (Montréal and Kingston, 1991).

⁵ Since submission of this article, the author has begun work on a book about the A.R.D. and the Third Republic, 1901–47.

adapted to an age when life-determining decisions tended to be made by ever-larger economic units. This creed was generally able to command an active majority among the Radical rank and file, and to do so in the Radical caucus near election time. Usually it just failed of a majority in the doldrums near the middle of each parliament's term.

All legislatures seem to suffer from mid-term blahs. In the Third Republic this problem was aggravated by the fact that the Radicals never commanded a majority of seats in the chamber of deputies, and by the sorts of politicians who sat just to the Radicals' right. The A.R.D. (and the even looser formations around it) was made up of people who really did believe that what was good for the Suez Canal company was good for the nation. They were almost always willing to provide votes for a parliamentary majority if it was evolving to the right, and would treat private capital generously. Thus the Radicals' ideology and mass-membership pulled to the left. Their usual parliamentary allies pulled to the right. Under those circumstances it is far from surprising that, far from being an anti-government party, early twentieth-century Radicals grew very adept at the uses and abuses of power. They legislated on the left at the beginnings and ends of parliamentary terms. They pork-barrelled with the centre at mid term. The standard joke compared the Radicals with radishes: red on the outside, white on the inside – and always near the butter.⁶

⁶ Alain, *Éléments d'une doctrine radicale* (Paris, 1925) was often cited by eminent thinkers such as François Goguel. See Peter J. Larmour, *The French Radical party in the 1930s* (Stanford, 1964), for Alain's unimportance, and Susan Rovi Mach, 'French radical ideology, 1906–1914: The audience, the medium, the message' (unpublished D.Phil. dissertation, Bryn Mawr, 1980) on *solidarisme*. Radical delegates seem in fact to have been consistently more advanced than the average of their elected members in the chamber of deputies. Accounts of the annual Radical congresses in either *Le Temps* or *La Dépêche de Toulouse* are especially useful, as they tended to report what happened, rather than what official Radical party accounts wished to stress. This article approaches its subject from the perspectives of parties and individuals. Compare it with the work of Elwitt, Lebovics and Nord – who all use more or less subtle versions of social class as their unit of analysis: Sanford Elwitt, *The Third Republic defended: bourgeois reform in France, 1880–1914* (Baton Rouge, 1986); Philip Nord, 'Social defence and conservative regeneration: the National Revival 1900–14' in Robert Tombs, *Nationhood and nationalism in France: from Boulangism to the Great War, 1889–1918* (Cambridge, Mass., 1991), pp. 210–28, and Herman Lebovics, *The alliance of iron and wheat in the French Third Republic, 1860–1914* (Baton Rouge, 1988). These authors (like Robert Young – though he operates from the opposite side of the barricades) tend to draw the lines of battle between a politicized working class and a (perhaps strategically) reformist bourgeois governing class. This article instead treats the socialist and Radical parties as having had contending (and occasionally allied) projects for reform; A.R.D.-style *modérés* (including Barthou) as the opponents (until the mid-1930s) of all social reform significant enough to be noticeable in the context of the times; and syndicalists, other workers, and still other voters as particularly important bits of the context in which the politicians operated. Noises from offstage, perhaps, but important noises – coming from the audience. This is actually quite close to the implicit opinion of Judith F. Stone, *The search for social peace: reform legislation in France, 1890–1914* (New York, 1985) – though Stone's reflexes sympathize with the S.F.I.O., as Young's do now with the *modérés*. To be fair, this author admits a strong sympathy for the Rad-soc militants of the period. He insists on believing that all the scholars involved are at least striving for balance, and that history is well served by their arguments and evidence, however partisan they may occasionally become.

II

Who were the Radicals? Were there enough of them in the national assembly to make a republic after their own hearts? Probably not. Certainly not every middling politician in France was a Radical. Elizabeth Wiskemann, for example, identified Paul Reynaud as a Radical. In fact the man hated everything the Radicals stood for. He devoted much of his political life to trying to build an effective mass organization of the centre and right which would fight Radicals, socialists and communists as members of the same awful tribe – efforts which the Radicals denounced as ‘electoral fascism’.⁷

Which politicians labelled themselves as Radicals at election time? One should consider as most authentic those Radicals who not only used the label, but also joined the party and were at least sporadically willing to put their parliamentary votes behind the platforms drawn up by annual congresses of the Radical rank and file.

Other factors have also helped the Radical party's size and strength to be substantially over-estimated. Obvious among these is the only semi-vertebrate nature of the French party system in the early twentieth century. Every part of the Third Republic's politics was at least five shades less organized than its British and German equivalents. For decades after the consolidation of the republic in 1875, it was perfectly possible for a well-to-do notable (a corporation lawyer, a retired admiral, the biggest local estate owner, etc.) to win office as an independent non-party candidate. Generally, he would choose a common label with some historic resonance – like ‘Republican’. Most such labels committed a candidate to nothing at all. They simply showed which broad slice of voting opinion he wished to appeal to. Those who arrived in the chamber of deputies often and easily jettisoned the flags under which they had run. They would join one of the even more numerous factions in the chamber. Usually the chamber faction which a deputy joined bore a family resemblance to his advertised position during the elections – but not always.

The slightly right-of-centre politicians who dominated the Third Republic's governments were precisely the most vaporous. Most of the sorts of *modérés* one found in the A.R.D. insisted that they were not really in ‘politics’ at all – and they went on insisting on it long after the Radicals (1901), the socialists (1904) and even some groups further right (such as the Republican Federation in 1903) started moving towards more modern, disciplined and coherent forms of party. The *modérés* could have formed a party based on their love of unrestricted capitalism and the social *status quo*. Occasionally, the A.R.D. thought about becoming that party. It repeatedly ran aground on some hard facts. The *modérés*' social position, their fortunes, educations and other gifts – all gave them power enough that they could safely indulge their personality

⁷ Elizabeth Wiskemann in her *Europe of the dictators, 1919–45* (New York, 1966), p. 105. For Reynaud's actual activities see his speech to the 1927 congress of the A.R.D. in the Flandin papers (Fonds Flandin), DON 313357, manuscripts room, Bibliothèque Nationale (hereafter BN), box 91, and Archives of the Former *Département* of the Seine, D.3M² Article 13, folder ‘Élections législatives de 1928, Documents généraux’.

conflicts, their prickly independences, and (above all) their insistence that their beliefs were not a creed like all the others', but were nothing less than the National Good of France. They conceded as little as possible to their political connections. They left as few traces of them as they could. One can read Caillaux' memoirs and not find a word in them about constituency or party politics. André Tardieu's personal papers contain almost nothing but thank-you notes for his books, and copies of speeches on the administration of agriculture. Yet each was a premier of France, and an active member of the A.R.D. at various times. This sort of behaviour leaves French elections before 1910 indecipherable in all but their broadest outlines.

The official guide to those elections is a chamber of deputies publication which was issued after each election, the *Rapport fait au nom de la commission chargée de réunir et de publier les programmes électoraux des candidates aux élections législatives*. It is also known as the *Barodet*, after the late nineteenth-century Radical who first insisted on keeping track of what politicians said and of what flags they flew during election campaigns – the better to check up on them. By the twentieth century, however, the craft of politicians had caught up with the *Barodet*. By the (admittedly super-complex) elections of 1919, even the *Barodet*'s editors admitted that they were engaging in educated and highly optimistic guesswork.⁸ It is also true that both the *Barodets* and the lists of groups which the chamber of deputies periodically published as annexes to its debates always seemed to miss a few members.

Fortunately, accurate and reasonably exact records of election results do exist for the French elections between 1910 and the Second World War.⁹ These we owe to Georges Lachapelle, motor of the Committee for Proportional Representation. Notionally an independent group – patronized by Henri Bergson and led (until the latter's death) by P. G. LaChesnais –¹⁰ the committee soon became little more than a front-organization for the A.R.D. The Alliance believed that France's two-round, first-past-the-post voting system – and the election coalitions which it encouraged – benefited the Radicals most. Proportional representation would cut the Radicals down to size, and give the Alliance more seats without the inconvenience of a party organization. It is a shame that Lachapelle's books tend to sit on uncatalogued shelves with their pages uncut. No one fully understands the centre of French politics in this era, because both its tactics and its principles make it exceedingly difficult to measure. Georges Lachapelle took the measure of the A.R.D. – and of the even vaguer entities around it.

Lachapelle took the official election results, and added affiliations which he got from the central offices of the parties. In dubious cases he consulted

⁸ *Chambre des députés, rapport fait au nom de la commission chargée de réunir et de publier les programmes électoraux des candidats aux élections législatives du 16 Novembre 1919*, p. 2215.

⁹ Georges Lachapelle, *Élections législatives... résultats officiels* (Paris, volumes for 1910, 1914, 1919, 1928, 1932, 1936) (vol. for 1910 with P. G. LaChesnais).

¹⁰ See the overly disingenuous: G. Lachapelle, *La représentation proportionnelle des partis politiques* (pref.: A. Carnot) (Paris, 1913). What may be the only remaining copy of this pamphlet is in the collection of the French *Centre national du gret, grand écurie du roy* 1101 78011 Versailles, *pièce* 784.

knowledgeable members of each party. This makes his books unique and extremely valuable. This despite the fact that his national results at the front of each book are always deliberately distorted to favour the A.R.D. and to understate the support of the Radicals. Fortunately Lachapelle – a typical centrist of his place and time – compromised his ideal of the truth as late and as little as possible. He consistently fudged his national figures, but usually did not distort the individual constituency-by-constituency returns, which it is therefore possible to count by hand. For the elections of 1910 and 1914 this yields the data shown in Table 1.

This table shows the basic fallacy of ‘the Radical republic’. The Radicals were an important party in the Third Republic. Yet even after thirty-nine years of growth and slowly improving organization, they did not have the votes to prevail on their own – or indeed as anything but one member of a fairly dilute coalition.

The Radicals’ difficulty is especially obvious in the results from 1910. The left was numerically stronger than the centre or right – but it was disunited. The Radicals were squeezed on their left by the Unified Socialist party (S.F.I.O.). This paid at least lip-service to Marx and – obedient to the Amsterdam congress of the Socialist International (1904) – gave only the most conditional and limited support to bourgeois Radicals after August of that year. To the Radicals’ right, socially conservative republican centrists of the A.R.D. type were always willing to bid for the votes of the faint-hearted or comfortable. The centre had much to offer: less onerous party discipline, better chances at office, rallying cries like free enterprise and (after about 1906) patriotism. Not least, it had connections with large corporations such as *Compagnie des Omnibus*, the *Société Nouvelle du Gaz de Paris* and the *Suez Canal company* – all of which had directors among A.R.D. members in the chamber of deputies. A.R.D. stalwarts tended to be offered briefs and directorships in the corporate world – whatever their origins had been. Centristism was still open to talent. Combined, these factors meant the Radicals lost many close votes in the ‘Radical’ republic.

The election numbers for 1914 were much more favourable to the Radicals. In late 1913 they had successfully pulled most of their loose fish into a party structure more unified than ever before, with a frankly left-wing minimum programme. This – along with having experienced governments of a rightward-trending sort for several years – put the S.F.I.O. in a much friendlier frame of mind. France’s two-round voting system let all parties test the waters in round one, then form coalitions for round two. A successful alliance of this kind in 1914 put the left almost out of harm’s reach: the A.R.D. and all the groups to its right could not muster as many seats as the S.F.I.O. and the Unified Radicals. To defeat them after 1914 would have required an unlikely coalition of the right, the centre, and a majority of the deputies from the remaining independent Radicals and the even-smaller left-wing splinters. Yet even a Radical and socialist majority would not have been the same as a Radical majority. One can imagine a falling out after a year or two, leading

Table 1

	1910	1914
Left-wing splinter groups ^a	NE	5
S.F.I.O. [Second International] socialists	75	101
Independent or republican socialists	25	29
Radical party (Unified Radicals in 1914)	148	172
Independent Radicals	60	39
Other centrists ^b	NE	58
Radical/A.R.D. double nominations	45	NE
A.R.D. (P.R.D. in 1914)	63	79
A.R.D./Republican Federation doubles	8	NE
<i>Progressiste</i>	5	NE
Republican Federation	53	53
Republican Federation/'Liberal'	17	NE
'Liberal'	54	33
Conservative	32	
Right-wing splinter groups ^c		42
Others	2	

NE, non-existent at the time.

^a Workers' party (*parti ouvrier*): 1, independent (but not republican) socialists.

^b Includes 19 members elected by the 'Federation of the left' (a special intergroup created by the A.R.D. and Aristide Briand for independent socialists migrating (like him) towards the political centre; left republicans (*républicains de gauche*) 9, republican democrats 10, democratic lefts 3, plain republicans 3, independent republicans 3, and similar smaller debris.

^c Includes 2 'liberals' who chose not to add 'republican' to that label in 1914, 17 independents (including the outright monarchist Maurice Barrès), 1 conservative, 1 (Bonapartist) plebiscitarian, and 21 rightists (*droites*).

Some of the above labels had different and/or looser meanings during the Third Republic than a literal translation now implies. In 1910, for example, 'Liberal' still usually meant that a candidate traced his political ancestry back to the 'liberal' (in the sense of 'parliamentary') monarchy of King Louis-Philippe. 'Conservative' was a euphemism for reactionary. Neither label implied any necessary allegiance to the republic or to democracy in the modern mass sense.

to a Radical/centre coalition in defence of property, probably falling apart in turn as the approaching elections of 1918 increased the influence of rank-and-file pressure for unity among the forces of progress.

In any case, the election of 1914 was effectively still-born. President Raymond Poincaré had been elected by a 1913 parliamentary coalition which stretched all the way from some Radicals to the pre-republican right. He now appointed premiers far to the right of the new majority. By the time repeated votes of no confidence had forced Poincaré even to the minimally left-wing

choice of René Viviani,¹¹ the Archduke Franz Ferdinand was dead. Any chance of the peace initiatives which the Radicals under Caillaux (re-elected and welcomed back as Radical leader despite his wife's murder of a scurrilous newspaper editor)¹² and Jaurès's S.F.I.O. had hoped to make – were lost. The social reforms which might have kept a Radical/S.F.I.O. coalition together for a year or two were set aside (with the exception of France's first effective income tax). At Poincaré's insistence, the centre and right were invited back into the cabinet from which they had only just been evicted – for the sake of national unity in wartime. With such a change in the cabinet Poincaré regained almost all the constitutionally questionable influence he had just lost.¹³

Thus the most reliable election data available seem to show that the Radical republic did not exist. The votes to build it were not there until 1914, and then only in co-operation with the socialists. In any case, World War I pre-empted 'the decisive effort of Radicalism to impose its doctrine and put its programme to work'.¹⁴

Before 1910 the A.R.D. preferred its members to run under other flags. To show that the republic of these years belonged to the business conservatives of the A.R.D. even more than to the Radicals, their political relationship has to be explained chronologically.

¹¹ According to *Le Temps* (which – as its name implied – tried to be the *Times* of France), Independent Socialists like Alexandre Millerand, Aristide Briand and René Viviani were far less dangerous than the more progressive of the Unified Radicals – people like Camille Pelletan and Ferdinand Buisson, who walked 'arm in arm with Jaurès'. Indeed, the Radical party was a 'mastodon', and its members were 'poltroons' who 'talk Radical and think Socialist'. *Le Temps*, 25 Jul. and 10 Oct. 1909. *Le Temps*, in the words of the later socialist leader Léon Blum, was 'not a glass house'. It kept its connections with the right-centre and with political power as dark as it could, but the connections were there. André Tardieu – who wrote *Le Temps*' foreign policy leaders in those days when Chancellor Bülow of Germany called the paper an independent Great Power – became a victorious Alliance candidate in 1914, and its acclaimed leader in the elections of 1932. In 1935 Prime Minister Flandin, by then leader of the A.R.D., was using the editor of *Le Temps* as an extra channel of communications to both Mussolini and the Pope. Chastenot to Flandin, 9 Apr. 1934, in Flandin papers, Box 66, 'présidence du conseil', orange folder: 'notes pour nouveau président du conseil'.

¹² *Le Temps*, 15–20 Oct. 1913, and 31 Jul. 1914.

¹³ See, particularly, two underestimated theses done for Arno J. Mayer: David E. Sumler, 'Polarization in French politics, 1908–14' (unpublished D.Phil. dissertation, Princeton, 1969), esp. p. 186 and Geoffrey W. Chapman, 'Decision for war: the domestic political context of French diplomacy, 1911–14' (unpublished D.Phil. dissertation, Princeton, 1971), p. 30; see also Kerry Davidson, 'The French Socialist party and parliamentary efforts to secure social reform' (unpublished D.Phil. dissertation, Tulane University, 1970). For arguments against their Fritz Fischer-esque view that French domestic politics would have come to apocalypse had not W.W. I intervened, see yet another Mayer supervisee: Arthur Fryar Calhoun, 'The politics of internal order: French government and revolutionary labour 1898–1914' (2 vols, unpublished D.Phil. dissertation, Princeton University, 1973), and my own 'L'Alliance républicaine démocratique, the dead centre of French politics, 1901–47' (unpublished D.Phil. dissertation, York University (Toronto), 1988).

¹⁴ Laffère, deputy and spokesman for the new Unified Radical caucus, interviewed in *Le Parlement et l'Opinion* no. 12, 10 June 1914.

III

In the beginning was the Dreyfus affair. The question of Dreyfus' guilt or innocence split the phalanx of over 300 Opportunist republicans which had dominated the chamber of deputies and almost all French governments for a decade after the failure of General Boulanger's plebiscitarian campaign in 1889.¹⁵ The affair's rising tide of unrest brought to power René Waldeck-Rousseau. His Government of Republican Defence eked out those of his fellow Opportunists willing to follow him with a minority of Radicals, with the socialist Alexandre Millerand, and with General Gallifet – the suppressor of the Paris Commune – now serving as a warning to the right and to the army itself.

From its own point of view the Waldeck-Rousseau government was more about restoring calm for capitalism than about revising the Dreyfus verdict. The premier himself decided for revision only after his appointment and one more careful review of the evidence. Waldeck-Rousseau's government was unheroic, but it survived where others had failed. It broke the army's trumped-up case and brought Dreyfus home. It also gave influence and some real power to Radicals and socialists, far sooner than their own gradual growth in popularity and improvements in organization would have done.¹⁶

The Dreyfus coalition outlasted the Waldeck-Rousseau government because the breach among pro-business republicans did. As the elections of 1902 approached, anti-Dreyfus Opportunists (or *Progressistes*, as they now preferred to be called), made no secret of the fact that they did not intend to forgive and forget, whatever the interests of their social class might suggest.¹⁷ Meanwhile there were those on the left urging the creation of a Radical republic.

Camille Pelletan was an advanced Radical and one of the more influential men in the party. He denounced the way the early campaign divided along ministerial/anti-ministerial lines. This was a ploy of the right. Instead – he wrote – the campaign should be fought between parties, and as a contest between republicans and reactionaries. Waldeck-Rousseau would probably resign right after the election, so why fight it on his personality or that of his ministers? Nor had Waldeck-Rousseau himself been – until recently – the friend of four-fifths of the men who made up his majority. From his past, his relations, his *clientèle*, he belonged to the enemy. He was in the same class as Barthou and Méline (who had helped keep the high-tariff, socially conservative Opportunist coalition in power). Pelletan admitted that when

¹⁵ The label was coined by Henri Rochefort (who before his Boulangist period was among the reddest of the red), in the first issue of *Les Droits de l'Homme*, 16 May 1877. It was a sarcastic reply to the insistence of moderate republicans that they favoured reforms and an amnesty for exiled members of the Paris Commune – but only when these projects became 'opportune'. See also Duroselle, *La France et les français, 1900–14* (2 vols. Paris, 1972), 1, 208, 212–15; Jean Bousquet-Melou, *Louis Barthou et la circonscription d'Oloron* (Paris, 1972), p. 94; Jacques Kayser, *Les grandes batailles du Radicalism 1820–1901* (Paris, 1962), pp. 265–7.

¹⁶ See esp. Pierre Sorlin, *Waldeck Rousseau* (Paris, 1966).

¹⁷ Chastenet, *Histoire de la Troisième République*, III, 217–18, 223–5.

faced with the assault of militant clericalism, Waldeck-Rousseau had opened his eyes and forgotten past grievances; but so had all good republicans.

If (Pelletan argued) Waldeck-Rousseau's government had done France a great service, it had made grievous errors as well. From the events of the year just past, one could almost believe that one was dealing with Méline's old ally again. The government had promised reforms: a graduated income tax, workers' pensions, the reduction of compulsory military service to two years. All were now indefinitely delayed – '*renvoyé aux calendes Grecques*'. The government was drawing its majority more and more from the right. There had even been scandals in the judiciary, to the profit of the enemies of the Republic. This, Pelletan concluded, could not be allowed to go on. Democratic reforms must be made, and old promises had to be kept. If they were not, 'a regime of liberty and free discussion' might be brought into discredit, and the way be opened again for a revolution and a dictatorial successor-state.¹⁸ Pelletan's Radical words must have sounded like a dirge to the men of the A.R.D. According to one of their most eminent members, resisting social reform was what more and more of them tended to be about.¹⁹

Wedge into so great a tightness, Waldeck-Rousseau's pro-Dreyfus Opportunists were forced to keep the very loose organization they had formed on May Day 1901 – the A.R.D. – ²⁰ and to sign in its name an electoral pact with their main partner from the Waldeck-Rousseau government: the Radicals. This pact – and a Radical pact with the socialists – ensured that the enemies of Dreyfus (and of Waldeck-Rousseau) usually faced only a single candidate – on the second ballot if not on the first.²¹

Yet even for a single election campaign the A.R.D. found it difficult to be part of the left. It thought that Waldeck-Rousseau's pardon of Dreyfus had been reparation enough. It admitted that a 'Not Guilty' verdict and reinstatement in the army would have been perfect justice, but said that perfect justice – still impeded by the army – ought to give way to getting on with the business of France, which was Business. The only major measure the A.R.D. kept in common with its election partners was a commitment to reducing the length of compulsory military service from three years to two.²²

¹⁸ *Le Matin*, 3 Apr. 1902. Pelletan's article appears as a close paraphrase instead of as a quotation because this newspaper is now only available in tightly bound volumes, and some of Pelletan's words disappear irretrievably into the bindings.

¹⁹ Chastenet, iv, 18.

²⁰ The preamble of the Alliance's first constitution (written by Pallu de la Barrière – the editor of its first newspaper *Le Paysan de France*) took up one and a half of its three pages. It read in part: 'The Republican and Democratic Alliance is an organization having as its goal the grouping of those Republicans who, be it in Parliament or in the country, reject collectivist utopias and internationalist hypocrisies, but who, sincerely democratic, are very decided to undertake all the necessary reforms, inspiring themselves above all by the great law of social justice which is invoked on all subjects and which, in fact, is currently thrown aside and trampled upon with such ease...[The Alliance bases itself on being] that great Republican party, of which Waldeck-Rousseau spoke at Toulouse.' This is taken from the earliest copy extant, dated 8 Aug. 1907 for the benefit of the prefecture of police. Copy in A.R.D. papers, BN, *manuscrits*, Don 37260, box 1.

²¹ *Le Temps*, 1 Mar. and 6 May 1902.

²² Duroselle, *La France*, 1, 265; Tony Revillon, *Camille Pelletan* (Paris, 1930), pp. 181–2. Both Radicals and socialists proved unresponsive to a later Alliance suggestion that a further reduction

When A.R.D. ministers like Paul Deschanel and Louis Barthou spoke in the elections of 1902, they sounded far more like Raymond Poincaré – who had gone into opposition after a brief foray in Dreyfus' favour – than they sounded like their socialist and Radical cabinet colleagues. The Alliance's idea of reform – in 1902 as after – was a vulgar sort of Manchesterism. The Alliance wished to reduce the powers of the state (public plans for workers' pensions were particularly dangerous), and to make rigorous budget cuts to ward off an income tax. The Radicals wanted constitutional reforms to finish concentrating power in the hands of the premier and chamber of deputies. The Alliance wanted to give more powers to a president of the republic who would somehow be 'above parties' (it would eventually decide it had found such a president in Raymond Poincaré – who by then was a member of the Alliance's own executive).²³ These suggested powers included reviving the president's old ability to dissolve the National Assembly – unused ever since the Royalists had abused it in the 1870s. The Alliance would also have let the teaching congregations who had opposed Dreyfus and the republic itself return to teach in France. It stressed the need to put 'collectivism' as well as 'clerical nationalism' 'on trial'. The A.R.D. called its platform 'progress'. The Radical *Dépêche de Toulouse* called it 'a policy of abandoning republicanism'.²⁴

Still, however odd a ménage à trois it formed, the alliance of the Radicals with the socialists on the one hand and with the A.R.D. on the other was effective for its limited electoral purposes. The most nuanced and accurate (and for that matter, the most Radical) version of the seat total is shown in Table 2.

The extra space in that table shows the break between the political centre and right as it was then understood. In the only partly settled state of party politics in France, the line of cleavage between left and centre went somewhere down the middle of the unaffiliated Radical category. That group contained many members of the A.R.D. – such as Chastenet the historian and its later leader Jonnart (governor-general of Algeria). It also included classic Radicals such as Léon Bourgeois and Jeanneney.

Vague as they are, the election results of 1902 show that – even lumped together indiscriminately – the politicians who labelled themselves as some sort of Radical did not have a majority in the legislature of their republic. And as has been shown, an unaffiliated Radical label meant very little in 1902. Some of those people had nothing in common with the Radical party beyond electoral necessity and still being glad that they had not shot Dreyfus.

Worse (at least for the A.R.D.) than having to run alongside the Radicals,

in the term of military service could be achieved by forcing all candidates for civil service jobs to serve longer with the colours than anyone else. ²³ *Le Temps*, 14–20 (esp. 17) Jan. 1913.

²⁴ Poincaré and editorial comment in *La Dépêche de Toulouse*, 13 May 1901; Deschanel on Government reform in *Le Temps*, 8 Apr. 1902 and *Le Matin*, 7 Apr. 1902. Compare the latter edition of *Le Temps* with the account of Barthou's doings in Emmanuel Beau de Loménie, *Les responsabilités des dynasties bourgeoises* (5 vols. Paris, 1954–73), II, 344–5.

Table 2

	1902
Socialists	46
Radical-Socialist party	98
[unaffiliated] Radicals	100
Republican Radicals	13
Pro-Government (<i>Ministériel</i>) Republicans	11
Republicans	32
Anti-Government Republicans	12
<i>Progressistes</i>	2
Mélinist Republicans	80
Nationalists	69
Conservatives	10
Reactionaries	64 ^a

^a *La Dépêche de Toulouse*, 29 Apr., 1 and 12 May 1902. Note that these totals were added up from the individual constituency results. The newspaper's own totals distort matters in no very obvious pattern.

was the way that many of its members won re-election 1902. Well-to-do, socially conservative Republicans who had supported Waldeck-Rousseau and his revision of the Dreyfus verdict now often found that they lost votes among 'solid' propertied citizens of their own sort – and more than made up these losses with votes from 'more popular quarters' of their constituencies. The Alliance and a left-wing electoral pact – although they seem to have left its members holding the balance of power in the chamber of deputies – also seemed to be taking them in a direction that few really wanted to go.²⁵

The standard view of France after 1902 runs thus:

Within a few years of the onset of the [Dreyfus] Affair, a presidential pardon freed the captain, and a legislative election brought a coalition of Radicals and Socialists to power.²⁶

This is at least twelve years premature. Indeed, if 1914 is excepted, there may have been no such coalition in power until the Popular Front of 1936 – which also included the communists and took place in different circumstances.

The Waldeck-Rousseau government did not consist mainly of Radicals and socialists. Its core was made up of the sort of moderate republican conservative

²⁵ This is one of the conclusions in André Siegfried's *Tableau politique de la France de l'ouest* (Paris, 1913). Siegfried's father Jules was a *modéré* and eventually a member of the A.R.D. André ran as an unsuccessful A.R.D. candidate in 1910. His books are permeated with the views and attitudes of moderate Republican conservatism. Their claim to being dispassionate science is silly. Still, Siegfried was one of the few men brave enough to delve into the impossible turf of French elections before 1910, and his Alliance connection – once known – can be taken to have given him a certain amount of insight into the way centre-right French politics worked. See also his *Souvenirs de la III^e république* (Paris, 1946).

²⁶ Oscar L. Arnal, *Ambivalent alliance: the Catholic Church and the Action Française* (Pittsburgh, 1985), p. 12. See also David Thomson, *Democracy in France* (Oxford, 1958 edn), esp. pp. 72 and 103.

who then went on to form the A.R.D. The elections of 1902 favoured the left end of the republican spectrum; and favoured it clearly enough that Waldeck-Rousseau recommended the Radical Emile Combes as his successor. But the new majority after 1902 still included men who would eventually be called republicans of the centre (a label which even that non-conformist André Tardieu would not dare use until the 1930s). A republican majority still needed centrists of the A.R.D.'s sort even more than it needed the socialists. Thus what counted in French politics after Dreyfus was not the periodic exchanges of insults between the French section of the Socialist International and ossifying Radicals like Clemenceau,²⁷ but the debate much nearer the parliamentary centre, about what the new direction of government would be. Were the Opportunists to forget their schism and go back to running France; or was the coalition which the Radicals and socialists called *Bloc des Gauches* and which the Alliance called 'Republican concentration' to find some further meaning?

The answer to that question shows how little the Radical republic existed, even with a Radical premier and a largely Radical cabinet. For there was further life left in the *Bloc*, but it was uneasy and short. Combes separated church and state. This made conservative republicans uneasy. They cut his government short. They denounced his use of Waldeck-Rousseau's Law on Associations as a weapon against the religious teaching congregations. They cried 'illegal', 'illogical' and 'contrary to liberty'. Centrists who supported the separation law – such as Louis Barthou – found themselves in very rough water back home. Barthou barely held off a constituency revolt, and then reversed his position.²⁸

The A.R.D. also denounced the Radicals for not being nearly rough enough on the growing labour unrest of this period – usually in the same breath as it was berating them for their excessive anti-clericalism.²⁹ It is still generally remembered that the only choice the Radicals offered priests was what sauce they would be served with. This fits the general tendency to paint them as dying of their own anachronism. But the Radicals' differences with both the A.R.D. and the socialists over labour relations were at least as important, and they are usually forgotten.

The Syndicalist wave in the years before 1914 is now explained away. Reformist rank-and-file union members elected revolutionary leaders because these drove the best bargains on bread-and-butter issues.³⁰ This should not blind us to the way things seemed at the time. Those in charge of many of the most important trade unions in France both looked and sounded revolutionary. Worse, the unrest seemed contagious. Hard-rock miners, other manual workers, even some of the skilled trades regularly went on strike. A utilities strike shut down Paris to celebrate May Day. Workers in the wineries

²⁷ For example, *ibid.* pp. 130, 176.

²⁸ Bousquet-Melou, *Barthou...*, pp. 120–1, 132–3, 171–3, 176.

²⁹ See Waldeck-Rousseau's own protest in the *Journal officiel, sénat*, 20 Nov. 1903; *Le Temps*, c.g. 25–30 Jul. 1903.

³⁰ See e.g. Peter M. Stearns, *Revolutionary syndicalism and French labour: a cause without rebels* (New Brunswick, N.J., 1971).

of the Languedoc, poorer civil servants, and schoolteachers were restive as well. These last two groups were already suspect in the eyes of conservative republicans for their general support of the Radicals. Now they not only demanded the right to organized collective bargaining, they took it in defiance of the law – a law which Radical governments then simply refused to enforce.

Radicals such as Ferdinand Buisson – the conscience of his party – argued that strikes and collective bargaining were a part of the evolution of the republic. They were the process by which workers would acquire the money and leisure necessary to take full part in civilization. The A.R.D., on the other hand, saw strikes as a revolutionary plot. Any economic demands strikers made were dismissed as ‘window dressing’ – concealment for a rehearsal to overthrow society. In the A.R.D.’s view, the proper role of trade unions was to help their members save for retirement, to buy homes, to go on company picnics, and to organize social services out of their own resources – so that employers and the state would not have to. Any departure from this model (and departures happened constantly), brought energetic demands for ‘a more vigorous maintenance of the peace’ and respect for ‘the right to work’ (for which read ‘strike-breaking’, then as now). One hundred times, the A.R.D. bemoaned the Radicals’ stupidity in pandering to the peril on the left. The standard insult was to compare them with Gribouille – the Little Audrey of French parlance – who threw himself into the water in order to get out of the rain.³¹

The separation of church and state made the Radical/A.R.D. alliance uneasy. Their different beliefs on labour relations polarized it. Breaking-point for Waldeck-Rousseau’s old coalition came over *L’Affaire des Fiches*. The Alliance accused the Radicals of bringing politics into the army, and forced the army minister to resign. Combes’ government died soon after.³²

Standard accounts treat the Combes government in general and the *Fiches* in particular with amused contempt. The Radical leader and his government are drawn as ‘secular sectarians’, keen to burn priests, but ‘timid, divided, and essentially unsure’ about every other issue. Even Jean Jaurès, the semi-saintly leader of the S.F.I.O. socialists, is not allowed to defend Combes. He did so, but even his admirers now take this to show that Jaurès sometimes ‘lacked essential integrity’ and even ‘fell to the level of opportunism’.³³ This contempt mirrors exactly the A.R.D. line at the time. This is not surprising. Much of it seems to have been researched from *Le Temps* – the flagship of business-conservative journalism in France, which had members of the A.R.D. on its staff and in its management – and from the *Journal des Débats*, which had similar class sympathies and cast of mind.

Neither *Le Temps*’ coverage, nor the contempt which it (and perhaps a general modern revulsion from politics) have inspired, do justice to the issues

³¹ E.g. *Le Temps*, 8 and 20 Oct. 1903.

³² For further background see François Vindé, *L’Affaire des Fiches...* (Paris: Editions Universitaires, 1989).

³³ E.g. Harvey Goldberg, *The life of Jean Jaurès* (Madison, 1962), pp. 294, 297, 332–3. He in turn quotes Daniel Halévy’s *La république des comités* – with approval.

in the *Affair des Fiches*. Relations between state and army had been a recurring point of breakdown in French politics at least since the revolutionary wars. The Radicals – while they did not have an independent majority after 1902 – seemed likely eventually to acquire one. The French army, meanwhile, was still largely run by the aristocracy – and made very conservative politics a necessary condition of senior rank. General Boulanger had begun his ascent precisely by pandering to the royalist beliefs of his superiors. The old Radical tradition of preferring a citizens' militia to a standing army was no longer realistic in 1903, but Dreyfus was still very much a live issue, and the Dreyfus case said powerful things about the army's capacity to do injustice, to cover it up, and to then recruit lovers of the social *status quo* to its aid in the name of national security. Tradition, discipline, rank, privilege: all were things which the Radicals at least liked to call anathema. The army made a cult of them. The plebeian, lay character of the republic – which the Radicals wished to emphasize – might occasionally require military support. Was the army loyal enough to provide it? It was not clear that it was. There was a strong argument to be made that the army of the republic should keep up with the evolution of the republic. In 1876 Gambetta himself had said 'I cannot admit that the government can be well defended except by those who love it'.

Arguably General André (minister since Gallifet's resignation in May 1900),³⁴ did no more than set out to protect the government's monopoly of the legitimate use of force. Despite his conviction that the army high command was systematically misleading him, André kept the boards of officers which had formerly screened all promotions – on an advisory basis. Competence was graded on a strict numerical scale. Trying to discover which competent soldiers were also in favour of the republic, André systematized what had been done in the past: he consulted his ministerial colleagues, lesser politicians, the commanding officers of the candidates for promotion – anyone who seemed to have something relevant to say. Eventually his sources included the Grand Orient of the Masonic Order – and this proved his undoing. The Masons' shadowy cross-connections with the Radical party are still unclear. In those days they were the red meat of conspiracy theories. When word leaked to the press, it caused a furor. Yet the political 'vetting' of army promotions was of long standing. Stranger yet, the only example even *Le Temps* could later find to cite of a man falsely accused by a *Fiche* was corrected by another *Fiche*.³⁵ Was there more behind the outrage than the shadowy hand of Freemasonry? Probably.

At first, the A.R.D. had agreed with the Radicals' desire to protect 'their' republic.³⁶ Alliance men saw themselves as the descendants of those republicans who had wrested control of the Third Republic from the Royalists, and who had imposed on it their own values and personnel.³⁷ In

³⁴ Beau de Loménie, II, 331.

³⁵ For the data see *Le Temps*, 17 Nov. 1904, and Mark Ira Kaplan, 'The Radical party and the army in France 1899–1905', unpublished dissertation, City University of New York (1976), and David Ralston, *The army of the republic* (Cambridge, Mass., 1967) – but note that my conclusions are not theirs.

³⁶ *Le Paysan de France*, 16 June 1901.

³⁷ See for example Sanford Elwitt, *The making of the French Third Republic* (Baton Rouge, 1975).

some cases this was literally true. Even Louis Barthou – no lover of the spirit of party – had had no qualms about delving into the politics of a schoolteacher (an inquiry which may have cost the man his posting) or about making a 1–1 identification between ‘Republican sentiments’ and having spoken in favour of Louis Barthou in the election of 1889.³⁸

André’s selective promotions were seen at first as a continuation of this trend. At the Alliance’s 1903 banquet, General André was seated at the table of honour. Here he had a good view of Henry Chéron – one of the A.R.D.’s founders – urging the government to ‘take control’ of all public servants left over from older regimes, and get them to ‘do their duty by making loved the government of the republic’. In case this endorsement was too implicit, the Alliance’s official newspaper explicitly praised André for handling army promotions himself, instead of leaving them to the ‘too-exclusive old-boys’ network of the army committees’.³⁹

There are reasonable arguments to be made against the *Fiches*. The Army had already gone through several changes of régime in France without becoming overtly disloyal. Military competence should perhaps be the only recognized criterion of service in the army of a democracy. But those were not the standards of the time. Nor were reasoned arguments the ones which the A.R.D. deployed after word of the Masonic connection leaked out. Instead Chaumié – an A.R.D. member but still Combes’ minister of education – fired a school teacher with great fanfare, for being one of André’s informers. Crisis-level language was invoked. André was suddenly called the head of a secret police. He was as dangerous as General Boulanger! Rational debate was not on the menu. Arguably, it has not been so since.

As has been shown, the A.R.D.’s disaffection from Combes’ government did not begin with the *Fiches*. Alliance men also made partisan use of military affairs before the *Fiches* were even heard of. When Camille Pelletan (now Combes’ secretary of the navy) gave new battleships names like *Liberté* and *Egalité*, and when he interested himself in the working conditions of sailors, A.R.D. members like Doumer denounced these acts as ‘provocations’. This accomplished nothing, but it does show that at least one of the A.R.D.’s many vice-presidents now saw the radicalization of the republic as bad for business. It also shows a tactical attempt to use security issues to break Combes’ government on terms advantageous to the A.R.D.⁴⁰ In this light, the *Affaire des Fiches* begins to seem less like a genuine outrage and more like another A.R.D. manoeuvre – one that worked. So Jaurès suggested at the time.⁴¹ Jaurès seems to have been right.

Combes tried to carry on after the A.R.D.’s defection. He substituted for André, Maurice Bertheaux – an advanced Radical-socialist, but also a self-made millionaire with a talent for making himself liked. Yet by January 1905,

³⁸ Bousquet-Melou, *Barthou*, p. 252.

³⁹ No author cited, *L’Œuvre de l’alliance républicaine démocratique*, part 1. Copy at the École des Mines, in Paris cat. Prof. 567¹³ H. 3; *Le Paysan de France*, 6 Jan. 1901.

⁴⁰ Revillon, *Pelletan*, pp. 168–73.

⁴¹ Goldberg, *Jaurès*, pp. 294, 297, 332–3.

seeing his majority narrow to 5 votes, Combes resigned rather than wait for defeat. He was replaced by his own finance minister, Rouvier, a foxy veteran of the Panama Canal scandal who was much more to the Alliance's taste. So was Rouvier's cabinet. *Le Temps* was jubilant:

What was broken eight days ago? Combism! A system of Government based on exclusion... on threats, on terror!

Combes was now compared with Robespierre – though without the latter's grandeur, to be sure.⁴²

The *Affaire des Fiches* set a pattern that lasted at least until 1914. The A.R.D. defected from its short alliance with the left. It worked instead, and with increasing success – to undermine any majority which looked likely to create a Radical republic – or a socialist one. To the A.R.D. these categories seemed more and more the same.

The A.R.D. played the central role in undermining the chances of a Radical republic. The shifting of votes in parliament over the Combes government's tenure provides an example of this. Two particularly pure votes of political principle came on Sarrien and Jaurès' order of the day for 12 June 1902, and L'Hopiteau and Vazeille's motion of 14 January 1905. Each was a question of confidence in the government's general policy. Such questions became very rare by 1905 – the opposition normally added every rider it could to such motions in the hope of attracting a few more crucial votes.

In the 1902 vote the government won by 309 votes to 85. All of the A.R.D.'s important members featured on the same side as the most radical Radicals – and indeed as Jean Jaurès. Attendance at such early votes was low because only a few reactionary *Chevaux-Légers* turned up to be defeated again so soon after elections which had been a disaster for them. The Nay list reads like a *Who's Who* of the anti-republican right. By 1905 the picture has reversed almost exactly. While (contrary to some accounts) radical Radicals such as Pelletan and Berteaux stuck with Combes, the A.R.D. (with the two exceptions of Thomson and d'Iriart d'Etchepare) now joined in opposition the likes of the Baron de Mackau, de Castelnau, Boni de Castellane and even Paul-Victor Beauregard – whose candidacy in 1902 the A.R.D. had gone to great lengths to oppose. Unlike in 1902, only fourteen members of the whole chamber now were absent or abstaining.⁴³ It seems clear that in tight situations the Alliance (and the even vaguer formations around it) held the balance of power. It used that control to impede (and usually to prevent) Radical legislation.

Period accounts agree that the elections of 1906 were the most hotly contested in twenty years – but that they were less about personalities and more about general programmes than those of 1902. In 1902 the spectators had known who they liked and howled down speakers who disagreed. In 1906

⁴² *Le Temps*, 23 Jan. and 11 Feb. 1905.

⁴³ Division figures from the 1902 *Journal officiel, chambre des députés*, p. 1841, and the 1905 *Journal officiel, chambre des députés*, p. 53.

Table 3

	1906
S.F.I.O. Socialists	57
Republican or independent Socialists	20
Radical-Socialist party	143
[unaffiliated] Radicals	45
Republican Radicals	83
Republicans	67
<i>Progressistes</i>	77
Nationalists	24
'Liberals'	1
Conservatives	79

orators were generally allowed to speak, and election rallies seldom turned into fist-fights.⁴⁴ When the elections were over, even *Le Temps* and the *Journal des Débats* conceded that opposing the left on the clerical question had been an error and that the left had won a majority. Yet, at almost ninety years' distance in time, it is not clear that 'the Left has won a majority' meant anything more than the Radical party and the S.F.I.O. increasing their seat totals. The A.R.D., whose members again had not run under its own colours, therefore decided to be Vicar of Bray for a while – again.⁴⁵ That there was still no majority without the A.R.D. seems to have been conceded before the voting ended: between the two rounds of the election, the Radical party executive committee – under Combes' direction – included 'the candidates of the *Alliance Républicaine Démocratique*' among those eligible for the switch-voting that was called 'republican discipline'. And when it celebrated the Radicals' first-round victories, *La Dépêche* did so with tergiversating words: 'the new majority is the old majority, but bigger. A final triumph depends only on our spirit of unity and of *entente* between republicans.'⁴⁶

The best approximation of those results comes again from *La Dépêche* (Table 3).

The Radicals had done well, but socially conservative post-Dreyfus centrists, of the kind best represented by the A.R.D., had prospered too – gaining roughly 30 seats. Even assuming perfect party discipline (impossible in the France of that era) a working majority could not be built from the left side of the hemicycle without including the republican radicals. Thus it is not surprising that the 'spirit of unity and *entente*' which *La Dépêche* had hoped for barely lasted long enough to form a Clemenceau government, and to finish

⁴⁴ *La Dépêche de Toulouse*, 3 and 6 May 1906.

⁴⁵ The Radical party issued a list of 13 A.R.D. candidates which it particularly wished Radical voters to support on the second ballot. This was more than the A.R.D. did. *La Dépêche de Toulouse*, 10 May 1906.

⁴⁶ *La Dépêche de Toulouse*, 8 and 10 May 1906.

giving justice to Dreyfus, who was at long last pronounced not guilty and re-integrated into the army with a promotion.

Beyond Dreyfus, little was left between the Socialists, Radicals and *laissez-faire* conservatives like the A.R.D. but division. The S.F.I.O. would not support a Radical government or join in a coalition with it, and repeatedly sought to outbid it on the left. The A.R.D. was standing by to provide the spare parts for a rightward-shifting majority. As Premier Clemenceau found both striking workers and the more progressive members of his own party difficult to get along with, he used more and more of those spare parts. Two votes on labour issues illustrate the process.

The major strikes of these years often featured the sort of violence in which no one stays neutral. Strikers and strike-breakers, unions, management, the police and (not infrequently) the army: all accused each other. Instead of trying to unscramble these eggs (a process probably productive of nothing but sustained ill-will), Radical premiers tended to cope by wiping the slate clean with general amnesties. Sarrien was the premier who succeeded Rouvier in March 1906 – when the latter's government fell over the technicalities of the separation. Faced with demands that crimes involving death or arson be prosecuted, he answered 'No'. What mattered, said Sarrien, was re-establishing social peace. His amnesty, Sarrien insisted, did not condemn, it did not condone. It forgot. Sarrien carried his point by 446 votes to 135, with Barthou's voice in the minority, along with the most reactionary conservatives. Sarrien resigned in October 1906 for health reasons, and was succeeded by Clemenceau. Two years later Clemenceau – repeatedly stung in his pride – joined the A.R.D. in denouncing the practice of amnesties as useless, and in demanding that 'anti-militarists, anti-patriots and fired civil servants' remain unamnestied. This left mainly the real criminals to benefit. When this was pointed out, and the S.F.I.O.'s Marcel Sembat pushed the point to a vote, Clemenceau and the A.R.D.'s spare-parts majority beat him.⁴⁷

Note in this connection the increasing importance of A.R.D. member Louis Barthou. Though already a significant *Ministrable* (the Third Republic's lovely word for an M.P. who had been and/or looked likely soon to be a cabinet minister), he joined Clemenceau's government as minister of posts and telegraphs – an office which the Radicals generally gave to young men from the Tarn with six months' experience in parliament. When the question of re-hiring civil servants fired for striking pitted Clemenceau against his own left-wing majority, the premier lost the first vote on the issue. Barthou – and an A.R.D.-centred spare parts coalition – helped him reverse that outcome just three days later.⁴⁸ Three years later, Barthou and Caillaux were fighting alongside Clemenceau – successfully – to prevent final passage of a pensions bill much amended by a left-wing majority. When Clemenceau took office as a Radical and as a reformer, Jaurès had noted the trouble he would have reaching such goals alone. But Jaurès offered help only on the Socialists' terms

⁴⁷ *Le Temps*, 11 July 1906, 15 Feb. 1908.

⁴⁸ *Le Temps*, 12 and 15 Mar. 1906.

– and these Clemenceau refused. Now, as Berteaux noted, Clemenceau was giving the shareholders and managements of the railways every satisfaction, and the railroad workers his ‘platonic sympathies’.⁴⁹ Another attempt at a Radical republic had been turned around.

After Clemenceau’s fall, France’s direction was not just away from the Radical republic, it was towards the sort of do-nothing night-watchman state favoured by the A.R.D. Premier Aristide Briand announced that his new government would be based on ‘appeasement’ of the quarrels which had divided France. This was coded language for a centrism favourable to business. At a first glance, Briand seems an unlikely candidate to lead such a government. Briand was a former anarcho-syndicalist. At this time he still called himself a republican socialist, and had many friends on the left. Yet his 1902 candidacy against a more radical opponent had benefited from the official pressure of the government of René Waldeck-Rousseau. As one of Rouvier’s cabinet ministers, Briand had eroded away as much of the separation of church and state as he could without sending the Radicals into outright revolt.⁵⁰ Briand in fact was ‘evolving’ to the right. He now made a speciality of persuading progressive majorities to follow policies so moderate they were almost regressive – to follow in fact what the A.R.D. called its policy of ‘*apaisement*, tolerance, and conciliation’.

In these efforts Briand was far more subtle than the A.R.D. knew how to be. When Alliance men like Flandin and Etienne suggested changing the Associations Law to make life easier for the clergy, it only gave the Radicals something to shoot at. Here was a cause that might rally a majority of the left. Briand, by comparison, was the Artful Dodger. He would discuss clericalism whenever the chamber of deputies wished to. He would be endlessly reassuring about the legality and correctness of all that was done – without ever showing signs of an argument intelligible enough to fight. Faced with a specific question, Briand would make jokes and then argue with the jokes. If interrupted in the middle of this process, Briand would pretend to be wounded – wondering why people asked him questions if they did not wish to hear his answers.⁵¹

Apaisement is still generally seen (when noticed at all) as Briand’s new contribution to the French political vocabulary – dating from his 1909 campaign for the premiership. In fact it had been an A.R.D. catchword of long standing. It was the Alliance’s own description of Waldeck-Rousseau’s government and had been a slogan favoured by the most anti-Radical Opportunists even before that.⁵² Briand was using the word to signal his

⁴⁹ *Le Petit Temps*, 15 June 1909 (*Le Petit Temps* was a quarter-page format supplement irregularly included in *Le Temps*. The A.C.R.P.F. microfilms include it).

⁵⁰ Beau de Loménie, *Responsabilités*, II, 371.

⁵¹ Bredin, *Joseph Caillaux* (Paris, 1980), p. 77; *Le Temps*, any issue in Aug. 1906, 15 Oct. 1906, and *Le Petit Temps*, 15 Feb. 1907.

⁵² Siegfried, *Ouest*, pp. 191–3; *Le Temps*, 2 Mar., 27 May 1901, 23 Jan., 11 Feb. 1905. This explanation of the Périgueux speech is based on Sumler, esp. pp. 13, 33, 52–3; and Chapman, esp. pp. 80–1. The two scholars differ mostly on the dates at which they begin analysis of the

conversion to social conservatism. The evidence for this seems overwhelming. It was to an A.R.D. audience at Périgueux that Briand made his *apaisement* speech. The text of the speech,⁵³ the interpretations made of it by the right-centre,⁵⁴ the parliamentary groups which then supported Briand most regularly, and the fact that anti-militarists and labour unions were conspicuously absent from the groups to be 'appeased' – all support this impression. For example, in late October of 1910, Briand suppressed a railroad strike by fairly indiscriminate firings and by mobilizing the reserve units of which the strikers were members – court-martialling the still reluctant. This seems a noticeably passionate and unappeasing reaction.⁵⁵ The Radical party congress of that year (at Rouen) featured a floor-fight over the Briand government. The government's opponents (led by Pelletan) routed its friends (led by Béranger) and condemned *apaisement* as 'a politics of dupery' led by the sort of 'clerical conservative' whose true faith was 'less in the Sacred Heart than in the Fat Wallet'.⁵⁶

Briand also couched his appeals in the sort of notionally non-partisan terms which the A.R.D. liked. He stressed that he would take a position 'above' the parties – as if by levitation.⁵⁷ The A.R.D. had no trouble decoding this sort of message. For them the good of France meant the interests of industry and high finance. Only the interests of other groups were 'politics'.

Thus went the years between the Dreyfus affair and the Great War. It is hard to find the Radical republic in any of them. Indeed, by 1912 the Poincaré cabinet was almost exclusively made up of members of the Alliance. Jaurès called it 'the substitution of the A.R.D. for the Radical party in the conduct of democracy'.⁵⁸ With this diagnosis the A.R.D. itself agreed.⁵⁹

'conservative resurgence'. See also Duroselle, *La France* 1, 345. For contemporary coverage and the speech itself see *Le Temps*, 20 Mar. 1911 and 10 Oct. 1909, and *La Dépêche de Toulouse*, 15 Apr. 1910.

⁵³ Périgueux (in the Dordogne) was one of the places to which A.R.D. stalwart Henry Chéron took Briand to speak. Georges Suarcz, *Briand* (5 vols. Paris, 1938–41), 1, 215–21. The A.R.D. already held one of the Périgueux' two constituencies. It would win the other from a *Progressiste* in 1910.

⁵⁴ Sumler, p. 59. Later repeats of the Périgueux speech tended to be made from platforms Briand shared with people like the bagman Alfred Mascaraud – who provided a counterpoint to Briand's noble chords by speaking ominously of 'the right of the worker to work despite the strike-mongers'. *Le Temps*, 15 Oct. 1910.

⁵⁵ Benjamin Franklin Martin, *Count Albert de Mun, paladin of the Third Republic* (Chapel Hill, N.C., 1978), pp. 236–7. *Le Temps*, 6 Apr. 1910.

⁵⁶ Tony Revillon, *Pelletan*, pp. 185–7.

⁵⁷ This was particularly true in a repeat of the Périgueux speech which Briand made at St. Chamond, on 10 Apr. 1910 – which is to say 15 days before the elections – Bonnefous, 1, 180.

⁵⁸ J.-B. Duroselle, *La France*, 1, 361.

⁵⁹ Lachapelle, *L'Alliance démocratique* (Paris, 1935), p. 30.

IV

When the cautiously progressive (and short-lived) Monis government fell in 1911, *Le Temps* dissented from the conventional wisdom. Monis' defeat, it insisted, had nothing to do with the PR bill which was its occasion. It had everything to do with Monis' failure to put enough socially conservative politicians in his cabinet.⁶⁰ *Le Temps* summed up: 'There are two majorities. That of the Left – and the real one.'⁶¹

Examination of the election results, of the people appointed to office, of divisions on important issues between the Dreyfus affair and the Great War, only seems to confirm *Le Temps*' view. The more leftward of those two majorities centred on – but was not limited to – the Radicals. The left majority gradually did better and better at elections, but was in office for only a couple of years under Combes and for a few months here and there thereafter – such as the tiny interval between the elections of 1914 and the outbreak of the First World War. Réberieux' question-mark looks amply justified. There was no Radical republic. It might be better to name this period 'the France of the Two Majorities'. Its quarrelsome, rotating elites we could call 'the Republicans of the Muddle'.

⁶⁰ *Le Temps*, 2 & 3 Apr., 23 and 25 June 1911.

⁶¹ *Le Temps*, 1 July 1911.